Q+A

SISTERS UNITED

After *Breathe: Into the Shadows* (2020–), actress **Nithya Menen** is back with SonyLIV's *Wonder Women*, where she plays one of many expectant mothers

Q. Testosterone-filled film sets are routine. What was it like to be on an estrogen-filled one like *Wonder Women*?
I loved it. Once upon a time, you'd have the heroine and her hairdresser. Now, you have more women on set. To have mature women...is such a different energy. I truly believe that women are more capable of being together as friends than men. We have a camaraderie and intimacy that men lack. I have never felt a sense of jealousy from women I have worked with.

Q. How does your film highlight sisterhood as a theme?
It is about a bunch of pregnant women connecting and picking each other up. There's nothing forceful or in-your-face, it is very natural. Female-centric films are also guilty of typecasting women. I am happy that we are breaking away from this.

Q. The film had an innovative marketing campaign with you announcing on social media that you are pregnant. Were you apprehensive?
I was apprehensive and nervous. I had just been dealing with a rumour that I was going to be married. I was worried that people would say, 'this is why she is getting married'. But I am glad I was a good sport.

Q. You and your co-star Parvathy are known for breaking the conventions of how an actress should be. How did you go about it?
By not caring about what people say. To stay authentic was so important that I never straightened my hair at a time when curly hair was not in trend. I feel South Indian actresses are so real, you don't have to be plastic or doll-like. I faced a lot of opposition in terms of character-shaming because I refused to conform. Now, it's time to be individualistic.

Q. Have you seen things change with the proliferation of OTT platforms?
There was a time when you were restricted, especially when you crossed a certain age. You'd be put in a box. With streaming, it has opened up. Now you can do a lot of different things. I am lucky that I am here at this time.

with Suhani Singh



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